

Sit-Down Meal

Fiction

It started the day Hollie got a brand new Frisbee for her birthday. She brought it inside to show her little brother Ash, and Ash — being Ash — immediately sent it flying across the living room.

It sailed through the air in a wide arc and landed perfectly inside the old sofa. Not on the sofa. Inside it.

"Get it out!" Hollie yelled.

"I can't reach," Ash whispered, lying flat on the floor and peering underneath.

They looked at each other. Then they looked at the sofa.

It was old — really old. Their mum said it had belonged to their gran. It had deep cushions, chunky arms, and legs carved like lion's paws. Hollie had always thought it looked a bit like it was crouching.

"I'll climb in," said Hollie.

"You can't climb inside a sofa," Ash explained.

But she could. There was a gap at the back, just wide enough. Hollie squeezed through into the warm, dusty dark inside the sofa — and found her Frisbee immediately.

She also found a trail of small green shoots growing up through the springs. She found three empty crisp packets. And she found what looked very much like a half-chewed rubbish bag.

"Something lives in here," she said.

"Don't be silly," Ash moaned.

Then the sofa moved.

It gave a long, slow stretch, like a cat waking up. The cushions rippled. Hollie shot back out through the gap so fast she nearly knocked Ash over.

They stared at the sofa. The sofa sat very still.

"Did that just—" Ash started.

"Yes," said Hollie.

For a long moment, neither of them spoke.

"We need to show Mum and Dad," said Ash.

So they went to get their parents.